



Shmeera

Children's Ministry Check-In & Safety — User Manual

A practical guide for Guardians, Volunteers/Staff, and Admins

Shmeera makes sure only a verified, authorized adult can ever pick up a checked-in child — and gives every family a direct line to their child's room during the service.

Version 1.0 — Church Edition · Generated for the current build of the Shmeera platform.
Every screen, button, and flow described here reflects the live application — not a plan for one.

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Welcome to Shmeera

Shmeera is a check-in and check-out system built for children's ministry — the moment a parent drops a child off before the service, and the moment they collect them again once it ends. It exists to answer one question with total confidence, every single time: **"Is the person picking up this child actually allowed to?"**

Every ministry that uses Shmeera — a single church, or a network of campuses — is its own independent, fully isolated **organization**. Nothing you do is ever visible to another ministry using the same app — separate rooms, separate children, separate volunteers, separate history.

BUILT AROUND YOUR SERVICE, NOT A DAILY SCHEDULE

Shmeera is used in short bursts around your service times, not continuously through the week — check a child in shortly before the service starts, and check them out again once it ends, typically an hour or two later. If you run more than one service on the same day (e.g. a 9am and an 11am), each is simply its own session — once a child is checked out of the first, they can be checked in again for the next. The only rule is that a child can't be in two active sessions at the same time.

The three roles

Role	What they do
GUARDIAN	A parent or caregiver. Registers their children, checks them in and out of a room, adds other adults who are allowed to pick a child up, and can message the room directly while their child is checked in.
STAFF	Runs a room — usually a volunteer serving that week's rotation. Accepts drop-offs against a code the parent shows them, verifies a pickup code before releasing a child, messages guardians, and can flag or report a problem.
ADMIN	Approves staff/volunteer accounts, manages rooms, watches every room at once, reviews the full history of what happened and when, runs attendance/pickup reports, and holds the few controls (manual override, data purge) that need a level of trust above staff.

THE ONE RULE EVERYTHING ELSE FOLLOWS

Generating a check-in or pickup code never changes anything by itself. A code only ever does something once a second, independent person — the volunteer or staff member actually standing in the room — enters it and confirms. One side alone can't check a child in or let them leave.

What you'll need

- A phone, tablet, or computer with a web browser and an internet connection.

- An email address to sign up with.
- For guardians and volunteers joining an existing ministry: an **invite code** from your ministry's admin (guardians) or a login your admin creates directly for you (staff/volunteers).

Creating Your Account

WHERE TO GO

Open <https://shmeera.com/> in your browser to sign up or sign in. Consider bookmarking it, or adding it to your phone's home screen, for quick access on service days.

Starting a brand-new ministry

If your church has never used Shmeera before, one person — usually the children's ministry director — signs up and starts it. That person automatically becomes the ministry's first **ADMIN**.

- 1 Open the app and choose **Sign up**, then the **"Start a new organization"** tab.
- 2 On the type toggle, pick **Church / Ministry** (the other option, **School**, is for the same app used by school drop-off/pickup programs — it only changes a label, so either works, but this is the one that reads naturally for a church).
- 3 Enter your church or ministry's name — this is just a label, e.g. "One Church International."
- 4 Fill in your name, email, and a password (at least 8 characters).
- 5 Check the consent box and select **Create account**.
- 6 If your ministry requires email confirmation, you'll see a "Check your email" screen — click the link in that email, then come back and sign in.

Joining an existing ministry (guardians)

If your church already uses Shmeera, ask your admin for the ministry's **invite code** (they can find it under Staff accounts in their Admin view).

- 1 Choose **Sign up**, then the **"I have an invite code"** tab.
- 2 Enter the invite code exactly as given to you.
- 3 Fill in your name, email, phone (optional), and password.
- 4 Check the consent box and select **Create account**.

NOTE

There's no public directory of churches to browse — an invite code is the only way to join an existing ministry as a guardian. This keeps each ministry's family list private to that ministry, which matters especially for a first-time visiting family.

Staff, volunteers, and additional admins

Staff/volunteer accounts are never self-signup. Your admin creates your login directly (see Chapter 5) and gives you the email and temporary password to sign in with — change your password after your first login. The same is true for a second admin account: only an existing admin can create another one.

Signing in, forgotten passwords

Use **Sign in** with your email and password. If you forget your password, select **Forgot password?** on the sign-in screen to receive a reset link by email.

STAYING SIGNED IN

Shmeera does not automatically sign you out after a period of inactivity — once signed in, you stay signed in until you choose to sign out. If your ministry uses a shared or public tablet at the check-in table rather than each volunteer's own phone, make a habit of signing out manually between services.

Guardian Guide

Your dashboard

After signing in, you land on **My children** — a card for each child you've registered, showing their current status and the next action available (Check in, Pick up now, or View status). If you haven't added a child yet, you'll be prompted to.

Adding a child

- 1 From your dashboard, select **Manage children & pickup list**, then **+ Add a child**.
- 2 Enter their full name and date of birth.
- 3 Optionally pick a default room — leave it on "Auto-suggest room by age" and Shmeera will suggest the right room based on the child's age at check-in time.
- 4 Add any medical or allergy notes — these are only ever visible to volunteers/staff actually assigned to the room your child is checked into, never to other guardians.
- 5 Select **Save child**, then upload a photo. A photo is how staff visually confirm the right child is being dropped off or picked up — add one as soon as you can, ideally before your first visit.

Authorized pickup people

By default, only *you* can pick up your child. If a grandparent, another family member, or anyone else might need to pick your child up after the service, add them to that child's pickup list first — under **Manage** on the child's card, then **+ Add authorized pickup person**.

- Give their name, relationship to the child, and (optionally) an ID reference and photo.
- Each pickup person has a status: **Active** (can be selected at pickup), **Inactive** (temporarily off the list), or **Blocked** — explicitly not authorized, with a reason staff will see if anyone tries to use their name.

WHY THIS MATTERS

A person can only ever be presented as a checkout requester if you specifically added them. There's no way for anyone — including staff or an admin — to add themselves to your child's pickup list.

Checking in a child

- 1 From your dashboard, select **Check in** on the child's card.
- 2 Confirm or change the room, then select **Generate check-in code**.

- 3 You'll see a QR code and a short text code, plus the option to print a paper backup tag (useful if your phone battery is a concern, or the building has poor signal).
- 4 Show the code to the volunteer or staff member in the room. Nothing happens until *they* enter it on their end and confirm your child matches the photo on file.

Once accepted, the card updates to **Checked in** automatically — no need to refresh.

Picking up a child

There are two ways to start a pickup:

- **Pick up now** (on the dashboard) — the fast path when you're picking up yourself. It generates a code immediately.
- **View status → Pick up** — use this if someone *else* on the child's pickup list is doing the pickup instead of you. You'll choose who from a drop-down before the code is generated.

Either way, show the resulting code (or the printed backup tag) to a volunteer or staff member in the room — your child is only released once staff independently confirm it.

IF SOMEONE IS TURNED AWAY

If you try to select a pickup person marked Blocked, Shmeera will tell you they are "explicitly not authorized" rather than silently failing — this is intentional, so there's never ambiguity about why.

Messaging staff

While your child is checked in, a **Message guardian** / chat panel is available from the session's status page, so you can ask the room a question during the service. Mark a message **urgent** if it needs immediate attention — an unread urgent message automatically escalates to your ministry's admin after a short delay.

Checking in or picking up multiple children at once

If you have more than one child eligible at the same time, your dashboard shows **Check in multiple children** and/or **Pick up multiple children** shortcuts — select several at once instead of repeating the single-child flow.

Notifications

The bell icon in the header shows updates for your family — a check-in accepted, a pickup confirmed, a check-in declined, and so on — even after you've closed and reopened the app. On a supported browser, the bell also offers **Get notified even when the app is closed** — turn this on once per device to get an alert the moment something needs your attention, even if you left the app closed during the service. On an iPhone, this only works after adding Shmeera to your home screen from Safari's Share menu first.

History and your data

- **History** shows every past session for your children.
- **Export my data** (on your dashboard) downloads a JSON file with your profile, children, their pickup people, and their session history.
- **Remove child** (under Manage) hides a child from your account. Past check-in records for that child are kept — this protects the ministry's safety accountability record — but the child no longer appears in your day-to-day list.

Staff & Volunteer Guide

Getting approved

Your admin creates your login directly, then either approves it immediately or leaves it pending. Until an admin marks you **Approved** and assigns you to at least one room, you'll see a waiting screen instead of the room dashboard.

Your room dashboard

Once approved and assigned, your **Room dashboard** shows three lists for your room, updating live:

- **Pending check-ins** — children a guardian has generated a code for but who haven't been accepted into the room yet.
- **Pending pickups** — children whose guardian (or an authorized pickup person) has generated a pickup code.
- **Checked in** — children currently in your room.

If you're serving in more than one room, a room selector appears at the top.

Accepting a check-in

- 1 Ask the parent for the check-in code — either **scan the QR code** on their screen or printed tag with your camera, or type the code by hand if scanning isn't convenient.
- 2 Confirm the child in front of you matches the photo shown on the card.
- 3 Enter the code (or confirm the scanned one) and select **Confirm**.

SCANNING IS A SHORTCUT, NOT A SHORTCUT AROUND THE RULES

A scanned code goes through the exact same server-side check as one typed by hand. If you scan a code that doesn't belong to the child on this card — easy to do by accident in a crowded check-in line — Shmeera tells you plainly instead of silently accepting it.

WRONG CODE

If the code doesn't match, Shmeera tells you plainly rather than silently failing or accepting anyway — try again, or ask the parent to confirm the code on their screen.

A child **transferred in** from another room shows "Accept transfer" instead of a code field — confirm the child matches the photo, no code is needed for a transfer someone already sent to you.

You can also **Decline / hold** a check-in (with an optional reason) if something isn't right — for example, a missing photo you can't verify against, common with a first-time visiting family.

Confirming a pickup

A pending pickup card shows exactly who is requesting the child — their name, photo, and relationship. Ask that adult for the pickup code (scan their QR or type it by hand), confirm it matches, and enter it to release the child.

MISMATCH OR FAILED ATTEMPT

If a code doesn't match or something feels wrong, use **Flag mismatch / failed attempt** to describe what happened. This creates an incident your admin will see immediately — always use this instead of just trying again silently.

Transferring a child to another room

Use **Transfer to another room** on a pending or checked-in child's card if they need to move mid-service (e.g. moved to the right age group). The destination room's staff still has to separately accept the transfer — you can't unilaterally move a child into a room without that room's staff confirming.

Messaging guardians

Select **Message guardian** on a checked-in child's card to open a chat thread with that family for the duration of the session.

Reporting an incident

Use the **Report an incident** button (always visible on your dashboard) for anything that isn't specifically a pickup mismatch — an injury, a behavior issue, anything your admin should know about, tied to your room.

Acting straight from a notification

When a parent generates a check-in or pickup code, you get a notification right away — from the bell icon — describing the request. Open it and you can **Accept / Decline** (check-ins) or **Confirm** (pickups) directly inline, without navigating to the full dashboard first.

THIS IS A SHORTCUT, NOT A BYPASS

The notification never contains the code itself — you still have to ask whoever is physically there for it and type it in. This just saves you a trip to the dashboard; it doesn't skip the confirmation step in any way.

Admin Guide

Staff accounts & the guardian invite code

The **Staff accounts** page is your hub for both staff/volunteers and your ministry's invite code:

- **Guardian invite code** — a permanent code you share with families so they can join your ministry at signup. **Regenerate** if it's ever leaked or shared too widely — the old code stops working immediately.
- **+ Create staff or admin account** — creates a login directly (no self-signup, no email confirmation delay) and approves it immediately. Choose **Staff** or **Admin**, fill in their details, assign rooms (for staff), confirm they've consented, and hand them the email/temporary password. This is the only way to add a second admin to your ministry.

For each staff account already listed, you can toggle their **background check status**, adjust their **room assignments**, and **Approve** or **Reject** a pending application — useful when volunteers rotate week to week and a new one needs vetting before their first Sunday.

Rooms

Create and edit rooms (name, age range, capacity) and mark a room **active/inactive** — an inactive room stops appearing as a check-in option for guardians and as a transfer destination, without deleting its history.

Children & class assignment

The **Children** page lists every child in your ministry with their guardian's name, and a room selector — use it to move a child to a different default room, for example when they age up between terms. This only changes which room they're *suggested for* at their next check-in; it never touches a session already in progress. Use the search bar at the top to find a child quickly by their name or their guardian's name.

Live cross-room dashboard

See every checked-in and pending session across *every* room at once, grouped by room. From here you can also:

- **Send code** — on any pending check-in or pickup, texts and emails that session's active code directly to the guardian. Use this if a guardian isn't looking at their screen (phone locked, noisy foyer) — it doesn't skip staff's confirmation step, it's just another way the same code reaches them.
- **Transfer** a child directly into another room.
- **Override** — a manual checkout for the rare case a parent's phone is lost or dead and no code can be generated. Always requires typing a reason, which is recorded in the audit log.

SEND CODE NEEDS SETUP FIRST

This button only works once your Shmeera deployment has SMS (Twilio) and email (Resend) sending configured. If a channel isn't set up, that attempt reports back "not configured on the server" instead of pretending to send.

Incidents

Every pickup mismatch and every staff-reported incident lands here, tagged by room and reporter. Toggle **Show resolved** to review closed incidents, and mark an open one resolved once you've followed up.

Audit log

A complete, filterable history of every safety-relevant event: check-in requested/accepted/ declined, code mismatches, checkout requested/approved, transfers, no-show flags, manual overrides, incident reports, and data purges. Filter by action type, room, date range, or search for a specific child by name.

Reports

Pick a date range to see:

- **Attendance** — headcounts by room and service date, useful for tracking week-over-week attendance trends across your services.
- **Average pickup time** — overall and per room, a good read on how smoothly your post-service pickup line is actually moving.
- **Incidents over time** — counts by type and date.

Data retention

Permanently deletes finished sessions (checked out, declined, or transferred — never an active session, regardless of date) older than a date you choose, along with their chat messages, chat threads, audit-log entries, and incidents.

THIS CANNOT BE UNDONE

You must type the exact cutoff date to confirm before a purge runs. Use this deliberately, as part of a retention policy — not as a routine cleanup habit.

Platform Administration

WHO THIS CHAPTER IS FOR

This chapter is for whoever hosts and operates the Shmeera deployment itself — not for a typical church's own Admin. If you manage a single church or ministry's own account, you can skip this chapter entirely; nothing here changes how your ministry works day to day.

A Shmeera deployment can serve any number of independent organizations at once — each one fully isolated, as described throughout this manual. A small number of accounts sit one level above that: a **developer** (platform-operator) account can see every organization on the deployment, something no organization's own Admin can ever do to another organization.

What a developer account can do

- See a list of every organization on the deployment, with basic counts (children, rooms, etc.) for each.
- **Activate or deactivate** an organization. A deactivated organization's users see a clear "account deactivated, contact whoever manages your Shmeera deployment" screen instead of their normal dashboard — their data isn't touched, they simply can't use the app until reactivated.

A developer account is otherwise still just a guardian, staff, or admin account underneath — it doesn't grant any extra power *inside* another organization's data (no reading another church's children, sessions, or audit log). Its only added capability is the platform-level list and the activate/deactivate switch above.

How a developer account is granted

There is no signup path, invite code, or admin action that creates a developer account — by design, no organization's own Admin can grant themselves or anyone else this level of access. It can only be set directly by whoever controls the underlying Supabase project, as a one-time, deliberate action on a specific account.

TREAT THIS NARROWLY

Because a developer account can see and deactivate every organization on the deployment, grant it only to the small number of people who actually operate the Shmeera deployment itself — never as a convenience for a church's own admin.

How Shmeera Keeps Children Safe

These are the principles behind the screens in this manual — understanding them helps everyone, especially volunteers, know why the app sometimes asks for one more confirmation instead of moving faster.

Two-sided confirmation

A code being generated never, by itself, changes a child's status. Every check-in, checkout, decline, and transfer requires a second, independent person to actively confirm it. A guardian generating a pickup code doesn't release their child — a staff member entering that code correctly does.

A closed, guardian-controlled pickup list

A checkout can only ever be requested as the guardian themselves, or as someone that guardian specifically added to that child's pickup list. No one else — not staff, not an admin — can add themselves or anyone else to it. A person can also be explicitly **blocked**, which is different from simply not being on the list: it's a clear, visible warning rather than silence.

Codes that can't be guessed or reused

Every check-in and pickup code is generated using a cryptographically secure random process, is single-use, and expires automatically — a check-in code after several hours, a pickup code much sooner. There is no pattern to guess and no way to reuse an old one.

Visibility matches responsibility

A guardian only ever sees their own family. Staff only ever see the room(s) they're approved and assigned to. Only an admin sees everything — and only within their own ministry; a completely separate church using the same Shmeera deployment cannot see or affect your ministry in any way, and vice versa.

A complete audit trail

Every check-in, checkout, decline, transfer, failed or mismatched code attempt, and urgent-message escalation is recorded permanently (until deliberately purged under a retention policy). If a question ever comes up about who checked a child out and when, the answer is always available to an admin.

Troubleshooting & FAQ

I didn't get my confirmation or password-reset email.

Check your spam folder first. These emails come from Shmeera's built-in mailer, which has a send-rate limit — if your ministry just onboarded several people in quick succession, a short delay is normal. If it persists, ask your admin to check with whoever manages the Shmeera project.

My child's check-in code says it expired.

Check-in codes are valid for several hours from when they're generated — long enough to cover a full service — and pickup codes for a shorter window since they're generated right before you plan to leave. Simply generate a new one from your dashboard if it's expired.

Can my child attend two services in one day?

Yes. Once a child is checked out of one service, a new check-in for a later service the same day works exactly the same way. The only restriction is that a child can't be in two *active* sessions (pending or checked in) at once.

Staff says the code doesn't match, but I'm reading it correctly.

Double check you're showing the *current* code — if you refreshed the page or generated a new one, the old one on a screenshot or a previous screen no longer works. Codes are letters/numbers only, shown in a fixed-width font to avoid ambiguity between similar-looking characters.

I was marked as a blocked pickup person by mistake.

Only the child's guardian can change a pickup person's status. Speak to them directly — they can switch you back to Active from Manage children & pickup list.

I'm a volunteer, but I don't see the room dashboard.

You'll see a waiting screen until an admin both approves your account *and* assigns you to at least one room. If you've waited a while, contact your ministry admin.

Why did I stay signed in after I closed the app?

By design, Shmeera does not automatically sign anyone out for inactivity — sign out manually from the header menu when you're done, especially on a shared check-in tablet.

I'm an admin — can I recover data after a purge?

No. Purging under Data Retention is permanent and cannot be undone, which is why it requires typing the exact cutoff date to confirm. Active (in-progress) sessions are never eligible for purge regardless of date, so this only ever affects history that's already finished.

I'm an admin — can I text or email a guardian their code directly?

Yes — use **Send code** on the Live cross-room dashboard for any pending check-in or pickup (see Chapter 5). This requires SMS/email sending to be configured on your deployment first; if it isn't, the attempt reports that plainly rather than pretending to send.

Shmeera — Children's Ministry Check-In & Safety App. This manual describes the application as built; a few capabilities noted in the product spec remain intentionally out of scope for the current version: SMS escalation specifically for unread urgent chat messages (SMS is used for the admin-triggered code-delivery feature above, but not yet for this), full offline sync, and third-party background-check integration. OS-level push notifications while the app is closed are implemented (see Chapter 3).